

The House That Remembered My Name

Part III: Room Thirteen

"Memory is not always a gift. Sometimes it is a prison that learns your name."

The staircase seemed endless.

Each step groaned beneath Daniel's weight, though none showed signs of age. The walls narrowed as he descended, forcing him to turn sideways in places. The air grew colder, carrying the scent of wet stone and extinguished candles.

The mansion above had been silent.

Here, silence felt alive.

It listened.

Daniel tightened his grip on the brass key marked **13**.

The metal was warm now, pulsing gently against his palm, almost like a heartbeat.

After what felt like an hour, the stairs ended before an enormous iron door.

Unlike every other door in the mansion, this one had no handle.

Only a keyhole.

Above it, carved deep into the stone, were seven words:

Only the remembered may remember the truth.

Daniel stared at the inscription.

His reflection shimmered faintly in the black iron, but something was wrong.

The reflection wasn't copying him.

It was watching him.

When he lifted his hand, the reflection waited a heartbeat before doing the same.

Then it smiled.

Daniel hadn't.

With trembling fingers, he inserted the brass key.

The lock clicked.

A deep metallic groan echoed through the darkness.

The door slowly swung inward.

Beyond it...

There was no room.

There was a moonlit garden.

Perfectly preserved.

Fresh roses bloomed beneath silver light.

A stone fountain flowed with crystal-clear water.

Fireflies drifted lazily through the air.

Birds sang softly in the trees.

Impossible.

The garden should not exist beneath the mansion.

Daniel stepped inside.

The iron door closed silently behind him.

When he turned back...

It was gone.

Only a tall hedge stood where it had been.

A little girl sat beside the fountain.

She wore a white dress and held a porcelain doll with cracked blue eyes.

She looked no older than eight.

She smiled as Daniel approached.

"I knew you'd come."

"Who are you?"

"My name is Eleanor."

"You live here?"

"I did."

Her smile faded.

"Now I only remember living."

Daniel felt a knot tighten in his chest.

"I've seen you in the portraits."

"You've seen all of us."

She pointed toward the fountain.

"Look."

Daniel leaned over the water.

Instead of his reflection...

He saw a birthday party.

Children laughed beneath bright summer skies.

A younger Daniel chased another boy across the garden.

Their laughter echoed clearly.

The other boy stopped near the fountain.

He looked exactly like Daniel.

Not merely similar.

Exactly the same.

Twins.

Except...

Daniel had never had a twin brother.

The vision dissolved into ripples.

"What was that?"

"A memory."

"It isn't mine."

Eleanor looked at him with quiet sadness.

"It is."

The garden changed.

Clouds rolled across the moon.

The flowers wilted.

Leaves darkened.

The fountain water turned black.

A distant church bell rang thirteen times.

The little girl vanished.

Only her doll remained beside the fountain.

Its glass eyes followed Daniel wherever he moved.

A path appeared through the hedges.

There had been no path before.

It led toward a greenhouse covered in ivy.

The glass was cracked.

Inside, hundreds of clocks hung from the ceiling.

None had hands.

Every clock face was blank.

In the center stood an elderly man wearing a dark suit.

He polished one of the empty clocks with careful movements.

Without looking up, he spoke.

"You've come later than before."

Daniel froze.

"Before?"

"Every cycle."

The old man sighed.

"You always ask the same questions."

"What cycle?"

The man finally looked up.

His eyes were pale gray.

Not blind.

Simply... empty.

"The house doesn't trap people."

"It preserves them."

"I don't understand."

"No."

The old man smiled gently.

"You don't remember."

He reached beneath the workbench and produced another diary.

Unlike the first one, this one was filled from beginning to end.

The handwriting was unmistakable.

Daniel's.

The first page read:

Cycle One.

Daniel flipped ahead.

Each chapter described another attempt to escape Blackwood House.

Each ended the same way.

Failure.

The next section began:

Cycle Two.

Again.

Failure.

There were dozens.

Hundreds.

The final completed chapter was labeled:

Cycle Thirty-Eight.

Its last sentence read:

I erased my own memories because living with the truth was worse than forgetting it.

Daniel's hands shook.

"No..."

The old man nodded.

"You wrote that."

"I've never been here."

"You've been here longer than anyone."

A violent headache tore through Daniel's mind.

Memories flashed like lightning.

A roaring fire.

A crying child.

A locked door.

Someone screaming his name.

Smoke.

Ash.

Then darkness.

He collapsed onto the stone floor.

When he opened his eyes...

The greenhouse was empty.

The old man had vanished.

Only the diary remained.

Outside, snow began falling.

Moments earlier it had been summer.

The garden no longer obeyed seasons.

Or time.

Every few minutes the world shifted.

Spring.

Autumn.

Winter.

Summer.

Again.

Again.

Again.

The mansion wasn't changing.

Reality was.

The whisper returned.

Closer than ever.

"Follow me."

Daniel turned.

A woman stood beneath a dead oak tree.

She wore a long black coat.

Her face remained hidden beneath a veil.

She extended one hand.

"I can take you out."

"You know the way?"

"Yes."

"Who are you?"

A pause.

Then she answered quietly.

"The only one you never forgave."

Before Daniel could speak again, she began walking into the forest beyond the garden.

He followed.

The trees grew denser.

The air became heavy.

Soon they reached a weathered stone wall.

Beyond it stood the mansion.

Again.

Not above them.

Ahead of them.

As though the entire estate existed inside itself.

Daniel stared in disbelief.

The woman stopped.

"Do you see now?"

"There are... two houses?"

She shook her head.

"No."

"There is only one."

The ground trembled.

The second mansion slowly dissolved into black mist.

Behind it appeared another.

Older.

Larger.

Then another.

And another.

An endless line of Blackwood Houses stretched toward the horizon.

Each slightly different.

Each impossibly real.

The woman spoke without turning around.

"Every time you refuse the truth..."

"The house builds another memory."

"And another."

"And another."

"Until you no longer know which life was yours."

Daniel whispered,

"What truth?"

The woman finally lifted her veil.

Daniel staggered backward.

Her face was scarred by fire.

Yet her eyes were kind.

He knew them.

Without knowing how.

Tears filled his eyes.

"Mom?"

She smiled sadly.

"You remembered my eyes."

Only for an instant.

Then her face dissolved into drifting ash.

The wind carried her away.

The brass key in Daniel's hand cracked down the middle.

A deep bell echoed across every version of the mansion.

The sky darkened.

Somewhere beneath the earth...

Something enormous awakened.

Not a ghost.

Not a monster.

Something older than either.

The houses all turned toward him.

Not literally.

Yet he felt their attention.

Thousands of empty windows watched silently.

Waiting.

Judging.

Remembering.

The diary in his hands opened by itself.

One final sentence appeared across the blank page.

Fresh ink.

Written as he watched.

The next memory will decide whether the house survives... or you do.

Far below the earth, a door unlocked.

Daniel looked toward the sound.

The mansion had shown him rooms.

It had shown him memories.

Now...

It was ready to show him the truth.

To Be Continued...